MEDFORD FIRE DEPARTMENT

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October 28, 2026

To: Honorable Members of the Medford City Council

Re: Medford Fire Department – Unmanned Aircraft System (UAS) Program and Ordinance 877 Compliance

Dear Members of the City Council,

The Medford Fire Department has established an Unmanned Aircraft System (UAS) Program to enhance emergency response capabilities, improve situational awareness, and increase the safety of both emergency personnel and the community. Utilizing an aircraft equipped with high-resolution visual and thermal imaging capabilities, the Department can provide Incident Commanders with real-time aerial information during structure fires, hazardous materials incidents, search and rescue operations, natural disasters, and other public safety emergencies. This technology allows personnel to evaluate hazardous conditions, locate individuals in distress, identify potential dangers, and make more informed operational decisions while minimizing unnecessary exposure to dangerous environments. The program operates under applicable Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) authorizations and established departmental operating procedures.

The Department recognizes the importance of protecting individual privacy, civil rights, and civil liberties as outlined in Medford Ordinance 877, *An Ordinance to Promote Transparency and Protect Civil Rights and Civil Liberties with Respect to Surveillance Technology*. The UAS Program is intended exclusively to support legitimate fire, rescue, and emergency management functions, rather than routine surveillance or monitoring of the general public. Aircraft deployments will be incident-driven, limited to legitimate operational objectives, and conducted without discriminatory or viewpoint-based targeting. Departmental policies will establish appropriate safeguards governing the collection, access, storage, retention, and dissemination of imagery and other information obtained during operations, ensuring that such information is managed responsibly and in accordance with applicable laws and City requirements.

The Medford Fire Department is committed to maintaining transparency and accountability regarding the use of this technology and to satisfying the applicable review, approval, and reporting requirements established under Ordinance 877. The Department welcomes City Council oversight and the opportunity to provide its operational procedures, proposed surveillance use policies, and supporting documentation for public review. Our objective is

to establish a responsible and transparent UAS Program that respects the rights of Medford residents while providing firefighters with a valuable tool to protect lives, property, and public safety.

Attached to this letter is a more in-depth explanation of how the Medford Fire Department will comply with Section 50-73

Respectfully,

Chief Todd Evans
Medford Fire Department

Section 50-73 Surveillance Impact Report and Surveillance Use Policy Submission

(B) Surveillance Impact Report

1. The UAS utilized by the Medford Fire Department is an Autel EVO Max 4T XE. The UAS will be operated by a licensed and department-certified pilot. This platform has been designed specifically for public safety and industrial use. Its payload features a wide-angle camera, zoom camera, and thermal camera.
2. This equipment will be used to provide Incident Commanders with an overhead view of major incidents in order to make better informed safety decisions.
3. The equipment will be deployed for incidents including, but not limited to, structure fires, brush fires, hazardous materials incidents, major accidents, missing persons, and rescue operations, fire investigations, or any other situation where the safety of members of the Department or public may be in jeopardy.
4. The only fiscal impact would be the initial purchase cost of the UAS itself and supporting equipment (i.e. batteries, replacement propellors). There are no subscriptions or other reoccurring costs incurred by the Department or City.
5. (a) It is the policy of the Medford Fire Department that the operation of UAS shall be carried out in a manner that respects and protects personal privacy consistent with the United States Constitution and Federal, State, and local laws. The impact on privacy and civil liberties shall be balanced against the governmental interests leading to deployment. As such, the Medford Fire Department shall not retain any photographs or video recordings of any incidents or training missions.
   The Medford Fire Department will use the Department of Homeland Security "Best Practices for Protecting Privacy, Civil Rights & Civil Liberties in Unmanned Aircraft Systems Programs" (12/18/2015) as its framework for protection of applicable rights to individuals.
   (b) Medford Fire Department is taking a strict stance on NO data retention of any kind that may adversely impact civil liberties and civil rights. The use of this equipment is a live-feed directly to Incident Commanders. More information can be found in the MFD UAS Standard Operating Procedure.
   - Page 4-5, "Legal Authority"
   - Page 6, "Authorized Departmental Use of UAS"
   - Page 7, "Prohibited UAS Uses", specifically bullet point 1
   - Page 13, "Misuse/Abuse"
   - Page 30, "Data Collection and Use"
   - Page 30, "Data Retention"

(C) Surveillance Use Policy: Attached to this document is the Medford Fire Department's UAS Standard Operating Procedure. Below will be cited references and locations within the SOP and how it correlates to the listed items in Section C. Further information will be given if not explicitly stated in the policy.

1. Purpose - Page 3: Scope
2. Authorized Use - Page 6: Authorized Departmental Use of UAS
3. Data Collection –
    (a) Page 30: Data Collection and Use
    (b) Page 30: Data Retention
    (c) Page 30: Request for Deletion of Accidental Recording
4. Data Protection – Page 31-32: Cyber Security
5. Data Retention – Page 30: Data Retention

Medford Fire Department is taking a strict stance on zero data retention with the use of UAS outside of the FAA-mandated flight data. Medford Fire Department does not have the computer hardware equipment necessary to retain the large amounts of data that would be produced by recording multiple hours of footage of incidents. If MFD were to record any photos or videos of incidents, that data would need to be retained for a period of 5 years, as it would be directly tied to an incident report. The other reason MFD will not retain any data is to protect the public's Civil Rights and 4th Amendment Rights to privacy. The UAS is being used as a decision-making tool, not for public surveillance.

6. Surveillance Data Sharing – Page 30: Data Collection and Use

As MFD will not retain any data outside of the FAA-mandated flight logs, there is no surveillance data to share with other governmental agencies, departments, bureaus, divisions, or units. The "MFD Master Flight Log" can be made available upon request. The information the flight log contains is the date of flight, the flight's purpose, how long the UAS operated, and the pilot and crew.

7. Demands for Access to Surveillance Data – Page 13: Misuse/Abuse
8. Auditing and Oversight: Page 8: Organizational Accountability and Oversight – UAS Program Coordinator
9. Complaints – Page 13: Misuse/Abuse